THE NATION **MANIPUR**

THE NEW FAULT LINE

A REKINDLING OF OLD ENMITIES BETWEEN THE NAGAS AND KUKIS OPENS UP A PERILOUS THIRD VEIN IN THE VIOLENCE THAT HAS GRIPPED THE NORTHEAST STATE IN THE PAST THREE YEARS

By **KAUSHIK DEKA**



BY THE END OF SEPTEMBER, Manipur's three-year-old saga of fear and violence had acquired another dimension. On September 26, two Naga civilians were shot dead and another two injured at Kalenjang in Senapati district, the sixth such incident in September alone. The death toll in the ongoing Kuki-Naga clashes had been climbing, but September has been particularly bad: 14 people have lost their lives. The overall toll since the BJP government of Yumnam Khemchand Singh took office on February 4—over 40 people killed and more than 100 houses torched till mid-September.

What began in February as a new fault line between Nagas and Kuki-Zos has since expanded, a stark reminder of how the conflict is spreading, and taking on new actors. Three years ago, when Manipur exploded on May 3, 2023, the conflict was between the Meitei-dominated Imphal Valley and the Kuki-Zo-inhabited hills of Churachandpur and Kangpokpi. The Nagas, concentrated in districts such as Senapati, Ukhrul, Tamenglong, Kamjong and Noney, largely stayed out of it. Naga areas even provided some of the few routes through which people from different communities could move without fear of being attacked in an increasingly partitioned state. That neutrality has now collapsed.

A NEW FAULT LINE

Three days after Khemchand took office after nearly a year of President's rule, an altercation involving Kuki-Zo men and a Tangkhul Naga man at Litan Sareikhong in Ukhrul district escalated on February 7. What began as a local incident blew up into stone-pelting, arson and gunfire. Houses belonging to both communities were burnt and people began fleeing ethnically mixed settlements.

The tension, however, had been building even before Litan. In January, trouble had flared up in Kangpokpi over the Tiger-German road, a route developed by Kuki-Zo groups to connect it with Churachandpur without passing through the Meitei-dominated valley. Parts of the route cross areas claimed by Naga villages, who said the road infringed on their